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**“Admiral Farragut** has ... the unassuming and the unpresuming **gentleness of a true hero ...”**

DIARY OF GIDEON WELLES, UNION SECRETARY OF THE NAVY,  
SEPTEMBER 12, 1863

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**A**merica’s greatest naval hero of the Civil War, David Farragut, was approaching his 60th birthday when the conflict erupted. He probably supposed that he had reached the peak of a solid naval career and could now look forward to imminent retirement. Instead, the war thrust him into action and the limelight of celebrity.

Farragut was the son of a Spanish immigrant, a merchant sailor who had fought for his new country in the Revolutionary War. But the most important early influence on him was American naval officer David Porter, who took the young Farragut into his household and into the Navy as a midshipman at the tender age of nine—a precocious initiation even by the standards of the day.

The boy soon saw combat in the Anglo-American War of 1812, when Porter’s frigate *Essex*, with Farragut aboard, cruised the Pacific in search of British whalers. Aged 12, Farragut was given his first command, when he took a captured vessel into port. In March 1814, however, the *Essex* was trapped at Valparaíso, Chile, by two Royal Navy vessels. Porter tried to fight but, with 24 of his crew dead and twice as many wounded, he had to surrender. Farragut was taken prisoner but released on parole, then took no further part in the war.

From 1815, peacetime service created a frustrating environment for any career sailor. Promotion was slow and chances to demonstrate ability very few and far between. Farragut seemed to